Krystyna Mishchenko

ARTISTIC JOURNEY

Ceramic artist | Sculpture | Visual art

From drawing to sculptural form

Krystyna Mishchenko is a Ukrainian artist working at the intersection of contemporary ceramic sculpture, decorative and applied arts, and visual art. The artistic practice centres on questions of human identity, inner freedom, memory, individuality and the relationship between the individual and the surrounding world.

Formal art education began in Kharkiv, with studies in academic drawing, painting, composition and art education from 2012 to 2016. This training established the foundation for further exploration of sculptural form, visual language and the possibilities of artistic self-expression.

The next stage was study at the Kyiv State Academy of Decorative and Applied Arts and Design named after Mykhailo Boychuk. The bachelor's programme was completed in 2020, followed by a master's degree in art ceramics in 2022.

It was during this period that ceramics gradually became the principal means of expressing artistic ideas: a material capable of bringing sculptural form, colour, texture and space together in a single conceptual statement.

Material as a language of artistic expression

Within this practice, ceramics extends beyond the traditional notion of a decorative or functional object. It becomes an independent artistic language capable of conveying complex emotional states, philosophical reflections and the contradictions of human existence.

Particular attention is given to the interaction of geometric and organic forms, the relationship between material volume and emptiness, contrasts of colour and texture, and the symbolic expressiveness of decorative elements.

Work with grogged clay bodies, glazes, pigments, oxides, smalti and stained glass opens possibilities for investigating surface, light and the spatial perception of an object.

The combination of academic artistic training and an experimental approach to composition occupies an important place. Sculpture, decorative ceramics, drawing and painting are understood as complementary means of developing an individual visual language, rather than as isolated disciplines.

Professional practice also includes developing artistic concepts, coordinating creative teams and teaching ceramics to children and adults. Teaching becomes an additional space for exchanging artistic experience, developing creative thinking and exploring different ways of perceiving art.

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Exhibitions & art projects

11.04.2024 | Resilience of Tradition — National Museum of Decorative Arts of Ukraine, Kyiv, Ukraine.

2023 | Art of the Young — exhibition project, Lviv, Ukraine.

2023 | Heritage and Innovation — National Union of Artists, Kyiv, Ukraine.

15.04–07.05.2023 | Roots of the Ukrainian Soul — Warsaw, Poland.

17.02–03.03.2023 | Roots of the Ukrainian Soul — European Union House, Riga, Latvia.

14–28.11.2022 | Poland – Finland – Ukraine Unit in Art for Peace — European Commission, Helsinki, Finland.

2022 | Art for Ukraine — international project, Brenna, Poland.

2022 | Goodness: Instructions — Polish-Ukrainian philosophy and art exhibition for ages 4–104; Wawerskie Centrum Kultury, Międzylesie, Warsaw, Poland.

2022 | Second National Biennale of Small Ceramic Form — Wejherowo Cultural Centre, Wejherowo, Poland.

2022 | Azymut Chrzęsne 2022 — exhibition opening, Chrzęsne, Poland.

2022 | Otwarte Ogrody Artystów Dąbrowy — one-day exhibition, Warsaw, Poland.

2022 | Beskidzki Dom Zielin “Przytulnia” — one-day exhibition, Brenna, Poland.

15–22.05.2021 | CeGlina 2021 — contemporary ceramics project, CeGlinaArt Gallery, Kyiv, Ukraine.

2019 | Best Work of 2019 — All-Ukrainian exhibition and competition, National Association of Folk Art Artists of Ukraine, Kyiv, Ukraine.

Awards & recognition

2021 | GOLDEN TIME International Arts Festival, London, United Kingdom — first and second places.

2021 | My Territory of Inspiration, third All-Ukrainian applied and fine arts competition, Lutsk, Ukraine — first place.

02–05.2021 | MALYUY.UA International Art Festival, Kyiv, Ukraine — finalist.

2020 | There Are Never Too Many Dreams, second All-Ukrainian art competition, Ternopil, Ukraine — first place.

Professional membership

Since August 2022 — Association of Polish Artists and Designers (ZPAP), Warsaw, Poland.

ARTISTIC JOURNEY

Continued

Identity, memory and the boundaries of human existence

A substantial part of the work is rooted in an interest in the human inner world: the desire for freedom, the need to belong to society, the capacity to preserve individuality and to experience inevitable change.

These themes are reflected in White Poppies (2022), where the interaction of a human silhouette with a geometric monolith becomes a metaphor for the tension between the individual and the social system. The work asks about the cost of adaptation, the limits of freedom and the possibility of preserving personal identity within established norms.

Another dimension of human experience emerges in Encounters (2021), a composition concerned with isolation, alienation and the need for emotional closeness. The interaction of independent ceramic objects explores a paradox of human communication: physical presence does not always mean a genuine connection, while the absence of direct contact can heighten awareness of closeness and its value.

Works in which emptiness becomes the principal bearer of meaning occupy a distinct place. In Shadows of Forgotten Voices (2021) and Shadows of 2022 (2022), recognisable human silhouettes arise through the absence of material form. This artistic device makes it possible to explore the duality of presence and disappearance, memory and loss.

In the context of the events of 2022, absence acquires particular emotional depth. A person may disappear from physical space while continuing to exist in the memories and inner world of those who remain.

In the Line of Fire also addresses war, destruction and resistance. In this composition, external confrontation is inseparable from internal conflict, and what has been endured becomes part of human memory and personal experience.

Artistic form thus becomes a means of reflecting on states that cannot be conveyed solely through literal representation.

Transformation: the viewer as co-author

One of the key directions of the practice is the exploration of transformable ceramic composition and the possibilities of direct interaction between the viewer and the work.

This approach is grounded in the desire to overcome the traditional distance between an art object and its audience. The work is considered not only as a completed material form, but also as an open system capable of changing through interaction.

This idea found particular expression in the degree project Identity Capital, devoted to the continuous formation of human individuality.

The composition brings together independent ceramic elements symbolising different components of personality: acquired experience, knowledge, convictions, cultural belonging, memories and individual qualities.

The possibility of rearranging the fragments turns transformation into a metaphor for personal development. Just as a person reinterprets experience and forms new internal connections throughout life, the separate elements of the work can generate many unique compositional solutions.

The viewer is invited to become a co-author by participating directly in the creation of artistic form. Each new combination of elements reflects individual perception, choice and the search for a personal interpretation of the whole.

This interaction reveals a central principle of Mishchenko’s artistic philosophy: identity is not a definitively established structure, but a continuous process of self-creation.

International exhibition activity

The artistic practice has developed within an international context encompassing Ukraine, Poland, Latvia and Finland.

International art projects in 2022 expanded opportunities to present original works and engage professionally with the artistic community.

Since August 2022: membership of ZPAP — Związek Polskich Artystów Plastyków, the Association of Polish Artists and Designers, Warsaw, Poland.

In 2023, works were presented in the Roots of the Ukrainian Soul exhibition projects in Riga and Warsaw, addressing the preservation and understanding of Ukrainian cultural identity.

April 2024 saw participation in the Resilience of Tradition exhibition project at the National Museum of Decorative Arts of Ukraine in Kyiv.

International exhibition activity has become an important part of professional development, creating a space for intercultural dialogue, the exchange of artistic ideas and the presentation of an individual perspective on contemporary art.

Artistic philosophy

Form never exists solely for its own aesthetic expressiveness. Its sculptural qualities, colour, texture and spatial relationships embody a desire to explore the nature of human experience.

The idea of contradiction has particular significance: between freedom and constraint, stability and fragility, presence and absence, individuality and belonging to a whole.

The works do not seek to offer the viewer a single correct interpretation. Instead, they create a space for reflection, personal experience and an independent search for meaning.

The development of the practice is linked to further exploration of conceptual sculpture, transformable objects and the interaction of different visual disciplines.

Art here becomes less a means of depicting reality than an opportunity to ask questions about the human being, the inner world and the capacity to determine the form of one’s own existence.